should not be adhered to. The leadership choices made had been bad decisions and I'd already been pretty vocal about it. It was bad enough that senior members of the team were looped out of important conversations and decisions – and worse that we were not even being allowed to take our usual seats on the damn bus.

It's simple. I'm no soldier. I won't just take orders and go to war. I will not say 'Yes, sir'. Not to just anyone. But I am a warrior. I will fight till the end for anybody who inspires me. And Shoaib Malik and Salman Butt were not inspiring.

With these complex equations and tensions within the team, we went to the World T20 with Shoaib as a contested captain. We lost to India in the final with that infamous scoop by Misbah-ul-Haq in the last over. It was a scoop that should have been a leg glance. Or a flick. Or even a paddle or sweep. But forget Misbah's shot selection. We all fought hard in that championship, though. I was Player of the Tournament. Tensions within the team prevailed. Keep in mind that around this time, although dressing-room politics were peaking, we were still performing.

Only Pakistan is capable of undergoing both – excellence on the field and deterioration in the dressing room. Worse, players were leaking information to the press about what was going on within the rank and file. Some of them were even being blackmailed by reporters to talk about each other and spill the beans about the fissures within the unit. The good thing was that many of those tensions remained behind closed doors, despite the dog-eat-dog politics of the Shoaib Malik era. However, statistically, it was clear that Shoaib's captaincy wasn't doing wonders for Pakistan cricket.

The India series in November–December 2007 is a case in point. It's a tour I'd rather forget. Simply put, Shoaib was just not inspiring enough. Eventually, he would be left out of the side due to an injury; an unprepared Younis Khan would take over the reins for the rest of the series. By 2008, the fuel had completely run out of Shoaib's captaincy. Only second-tier teams like Zimbabwe or Bangladesh were coming to tour Pakistan, anyway.

Then, in January 2009, Younis bhai – who had earlier been offered the captaincy position twice and he had turned it down – accepted an offer to become skipper of the side. It was heralded as a good decision, a long time coming. One had hoped that Pakistan cricket would rise from there. However, about a month later, tragedy struck when the bus carrying the touring Lankan side was attacked by armed gunmen in Lahore. The match was abandoned, declared drawn. And with that, Pakistan cricket hit rock bottom.

I will never forget that terrible day – the attack on 3 March 2009. I was in Muzaffarabad – the capital of the Pakistan-administered territory of Kashmir – with Moin Khan, busy with flood-relief work and helping out with the inauguration of a hospital. It's ironic that I heard about the terror attack when I was in one of the most conflicted and militarized regions in the world. Moin and I couldn't believe what we'd heard. Immediately, we feared the worst, that we'd lost our teammates and colleagues, and worried about what would now happen to Pakistan and Pakistan cricket.

Politically speaking, the attack was inevitable, really. After the 9/11 terror attacks in the US, Pakistan had chosen to fight the war against terror as a partner of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO). But it was a war that wasn't ours to begin with. Yes, we had chosen to side with the Americans, but I'm not sure if we were prepared for the implications of teaming up with them.